



Which artistic
strategies can Digital
Calligraffiti use to add
new contents and forms
to historical western
monuments, symbols, and
icons

case study:

gent:

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Which artistic strategies can Digital Calligraffiti use to
add new contents and forms to historical western
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by

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Introduction:

From handwriting to Digital Calligraffiti:

The journey of writing started with a mark of a footstep in the mud for someone who had walked here before, this footstep later on took a shape and it held more decipherable information later on. My project discusses mainly Digital Calligraffiti, in order to break it down I will first briefly mention how writing started and evolved into calligraphy, then graffiti, Calligraffiti, and lastly Digital Calligraffiti.

Writing first started in Mesopotamia (present-day Iraq), , the clay tablets that were found there had symbols that looked like nails in specific arrangement that were translated later on to words. This language was then called Cuneiform.

The flow of writing then evolved in Egypt around 3500 BC, with the wonderful script of Egyptian hieroglyph , which I consider to be the earliest form of calligraphy. (1)

What separates Calligraphy from handwriting is mainly the strict rules of calligraphy for example one has to maintain the shape of any letter with accordance to those strict rules, the letter has to be exactly the same in shape, proportions and anatomy regardless of where it's placed.

The earliest form of graffiti was most likely the cave paintings and drawings, that is if we were to consider graffiti in the broadest definition as any form of a visual act on a wall.

The art of Arabic Calligraphy was highly appreciated in the islamic culture since the rules of islam forbids the manifestation of portraits or anything with a sole, therefore there were other alternatives such as the geometrical patterns and of course the calligraphy. The calligraphy was used to decorate mosques, tombs and other holy places like Kaaba in Mecca and Dome of the Rock in Jerusalem with verses of Qur'an.



Fig. 1
Kaaba at Mecca

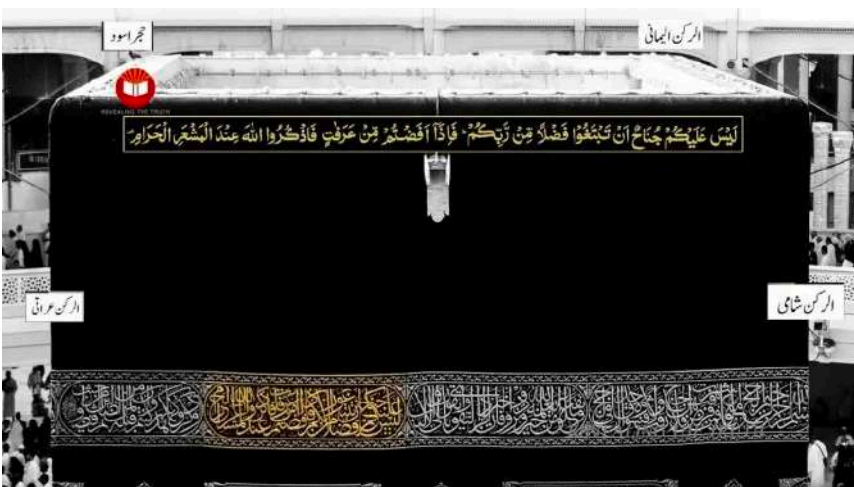


Fig. 2
لَيْسَ عَلَيْكُمْ جُنَاحٌ أَنْ تَبْتَغُوا فَضْلًا مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ
فَإِذَا أَفَضْتُمْ مِنْ عَرَفَاتٍ فَادْكُرُوا اللَّهَ عِنْدَ الْمَشْعَرِ
الْحَرَامِ
Laysa AAalaykum junahun an
tabtaghoo fadlan min rabbikum
faitha afadtum min AAarafatin
faothkuroo Allaha AAinda
almashAAari alharami
198 Al-Baqarah

English
It is no crime in you if ye seek of
the bounty of your Lord (during
pilgrimage). Then when ye pour
down from (Mount) Arafat,
celebrate the praises of Allah at the
Sacred Monument



Fig. 3
Dome of the rock -
Jerusalem (Al Quds)\
Palestine



Fig. 4
Dome of the rock
calligraphy close-up -
Jerusalem (Al Quds)\
Palestine

Surah Ya-Sin*

I believe that in order to have your own identity as an artist, you really have to see and maybe study previous related experiences so you “won’t create the wheel again”. Taking that in mind, I studied classic Arabic calligraphy for a few years, knowing the basics was not enough, calligraphy is more of a practice and exercise, I decided on one point to break free from the traditional school because I didn’t find the freedom I wanted as a street artist, after studying the anatomy of letters of the main seven styles of Arabic calligraphy and the sub-

styles I was able to fuse three traditional Arabic calligraphy styles: Thuluth, Diwani, and Sunbuli to come up with my own style .



Fig. 5

Thuluth calligraphy style example

عَلَى الرَّشْدِ ثَبَّتْ يَا رَشِيدَ عَزَائِمِي عَلَى الصَّبْرِ هَبْ لِي (يَا صَبُورَ تَحْمَلَا)

ealaa alrushd thbbt ya rashid eazayimi ealaa alsabr hab li (ya sabur tahamula)

On maturity, make me firm, O Rashid, on patience. Grant me (O patient, endurance)

Thuluth: There are more than one theory for the origin of the name, one that says this style of writing had a specific pen for it where the blade is one third of the radius of the pen itself, another theory says that the thinnest part of a letter of that style is one third of the thickest part of the same letter, a third theory claims that one-third of each letter slopes, but unfortunately there was no solid proof to back any of these theories.



Fig. 6

Diwani calligraphy style example

حسبي الله ونعم الوكيل

hasabi allah waniem alwakil

Allah is my suffice, and the best deputy

Diwani: This type of calligraphy font was developed during the Ottoman period, and it was developed for the official use, and the word Diwan in Arabic refers to a department in the state e.g. Diwan Bait Al Mal: Department of treasury. From there this style took its name, Diwani - related to the Diwan.

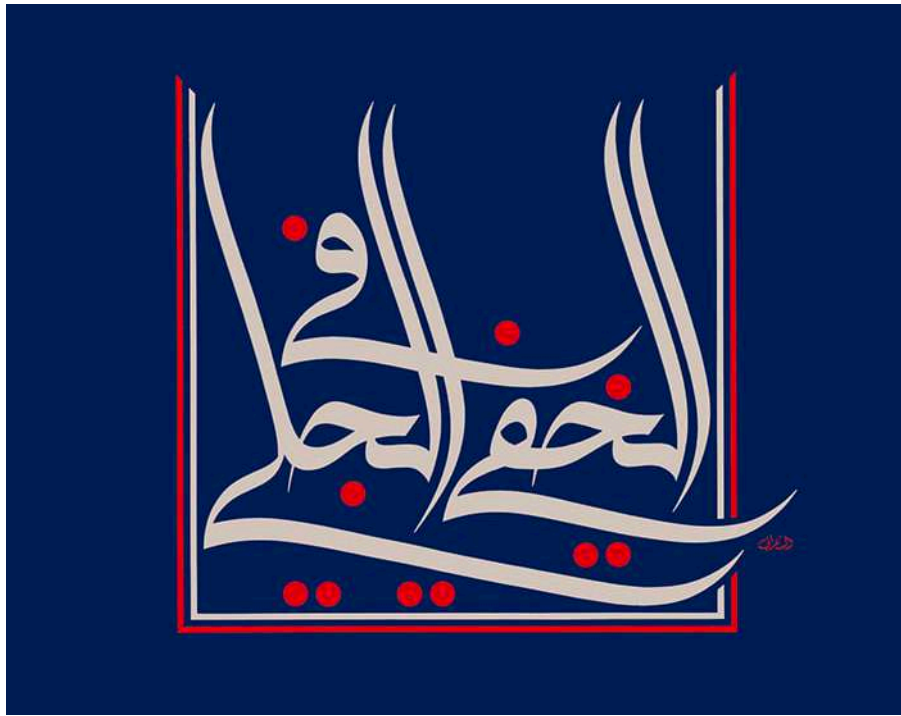


Fig. 7
Sunbuli calligraphy style example
الخفي في الجلي
Al khaki fil Jalii

The hidden is revealed in the apparent

Sunbuli: This style took its name from the Arabic word "Sunbula" which is the ear of wheat that shapes the main anatomy of this style, it was developed from the Diwani style by Aref Hikmat in Istanbul 1914, and it was reincarnated by Mounir Al Shaarani from Syria in the early 2000s.

I took this knowledge and started to practice it on walls in public spaces in the city of Ramallah in Palestine where I used to live at the time, I was obsessed with Graffiti and the influence it leaves on people, the origin of the word Graffiti comes from Graffio in Italian which means scratch, and as Britannica

describes it: "it is a form of visual communication, usually illegal, involving the unauthorised marking of public space by an individual or group." (9).

I started developing my style in the early 2012 by experimenting on the anatomy of the the three styles mentioned earlier, the process took almost two years to finally come as a unique way of writing, mixing my knowledge of calligraphy and my practice as a street artist I was able to form my way of doing this fusion of Graffiti and Calligraphy that is known as Calligraffiti.

Calligraffiti, is a term was first coined by Niels Shoe Meulmann in 2007 (10).

In 2016 was the birth of Digital Calligraffiti as an urban art performance which mainly aims to transfer the urban ecosystem into a canvas of expression by joining Calligraffiti and media art, it was created by the urban media art curator Susa Pop, Public Art Lab, Don Stone, multimedia artist Michael Ang and I - Hamza AbuAyyash. For that we invented a device to bridge the gap between the hand of a calligrapher and the digital computerised light show and we called it "Infl3ctor".

"Infl3ctor is a device that was built in an attempt to bridge the gap between the analogue and the digital, the messenger and the audience, the art of writing and the digital visualisation. It was especially designed for Digital Calligraffiti by the new media artist and engineer Michael Ang in collaboration with the new media and calligraffiti artist Hamza Abu Ayyash. Infl3ctor introduces new possibilities of communication and cultural expression.

This interactive tool allows the artworks – messages to have a unique outcome even in their digital form by preserving the hand of the artist. The calligraffiti

tags are composed and projected in real time enabling a dialogue between citizens of the same cities or of distant cities through networked scenarios.

During the performances the audience is encouraged to participate and write their own messages. In a time where the unit is swallowed by the mass and the voices of the social groups are not equally heard, this installation offers individuals an equal opportunity of expression with high visibility.”(11).

Digital Calligraffiti is a technique which makes voice more visible to the public, it's a way to help oppressed people, and those who are unheard project their messages, their hopes and their dreams on facades, it's a way that can amplify the impact of a messages so it can be seen.

Digital Calligraffiti Networked Scenarios:

This method is usually used to do a performance simultaneously in two different locations via Internet where every location has a good internet connection, a beamer projector, a computer, and the Infl3ctor. The two stations are able to communicate creating layered Digital Calligraffiti pieces on different structures at both ends.

In September 2017, the need for Digital Calligraffiti Networked Scenarios was first realised during a performance and a workshop that were scheduled in Beirut - Lebanon which I was a part of but due to political issues with the Lebanese I was denied entry to the country and I had to take the same flight

back to Amman - Jordan, upon arrival I built an Infl3ctor from scratch and joined the rest of the crew simultaneously in the workshop, me being in Amman and them in Beirut.

Light vanquishes darkness through letters, letters from words, and words are a form of knowledge which dissolves ignorance. This technique crosses borders, it can connect different continents to project on one facade in real time.

My project is a scenario of how certain historical western monuments, icons, and symbols could interact with futuristic forms of art using oriental scripts.

Process of the research:

My first intention was totally different, my main aim was researching old Canaanite gods from Levant, focusing on the main four: El: the father of all gods, Ashira: the mother of all gods, Baal: the son god, Anat: the daughter goddess, it took me a whole year to figure out how to bring them back to life into our present time from more than 6000 years ago.

The process was not easy, and I went through many discussions with friends who were artists, researchers, and intellectuals to find out the best way to present this topic to the western culture, I started by recreating the gods' characters then making a clay sculpture sketch for each one of them, in which I included the result of my researches, readings and discussions in visual form

The project escalated in my brain and imagination, a parallel branch of the master project was also planned, which was "God in a bottle", it was designed in the form of message put in a bottle, but with some futuristic tweaks such as a solar panel that supplies power to a GPS tracker in the bottle that also holds an illustration of one of the gods as it was recreated by me, a brief description of the project, four seeds of the fruits that I considered the signature of the Levant: Olive, Date, Wheat, and Barley.

I wanted to find a connection between the two projects, since both of them discusses the same topic, and I felt that the "God in a bottle" might describe the notion of "double consciousness" in a more powerful manner than simply having it in an explanatory text placed under the sculptures as I originally intended to do. I was planning on putting the four sculptures in four countries, then throwing the bottles from one location to the sea so I could track them on the day I reveal the Futuristic Canaanite show.

Later on I shifted from sculpturing into making comics, mainly for the huge amount of expenses I will need in order to produce the four pieces and the logistics I have to organise if I wanted to present the project as I planned it. I kept the "God in a bottle" part and merged it with the last frame of the comics where the character - the God, throws a bottle in the sea, with a QR code in the next page that directs the reader to the webpage where they can really track the bottle that was thrown by that God.

Again I reached a closed door, mainly because I am not a storyteller, I couldn't write a story to illustrate later, although if I had a script I would easily convert it into frames since part of my experience is creating storyboard for TV advertisements and music videoclips.

I described this problem to my practical mentor Chokri Bin Chikha in one of our face to face meetings, we then discussed my progress for my master project in which I faced major difficulties regarding building a story to illustrate later on in comics style.

Chokri asked me about a performance that I had in October 2020 in the Abby of St. Bavo in Gent, the performance was part of the city's celebration of Van Eyck, it was within an exposition for VOEM vzw called "Wollah! Van Eyck Was Here. Lamb of God/عزف الحروف".

In the abbey, and in my first visit to examine the space, I noticed above the gate a sculpture of Jesus crucified but it was missing both arms from the shoulders, I thought that this is going to be the place where I will perform and project my Digital calligraffiti on, I wanted to complete the missing parts of the statue by projecting wings with digital calligraffiti technique of quotes from the Bible, and Sufi poetry.

Upon seeing videos and photos of my performance he advised me to change my master project to match my practice, considering the fact that I have more than six years of experience in the Digital Calligraffiti field, and for being one of the pioneers in this form of art, Chokri thought it would be a more solid art

project with less experimenting in the media and more researching in the core of the performance itself, starting with the history of the locations that are selected for the performance, the quotes that are being used to form the projection and their relation to the space and the surface of the performance, and the integration of the shapes formed by the quotes on the architectural front.

He also saw potential in this practice to grow more if I focused on monuments in Gent firstly and then expand world wide, in a more story based performances linked to the monuments and landmarks I intend to project my work on, unlike my previous work which was purely for the visuals.

Chokri then offered to help me with getting a tour guide in Gent to make several tours visiting the most important historical, religious and political landmarks and sites to get a more clear idea of the rich history of Gent which will ultimately help me in deciding what and where I will choose to do the digital calligraffiti for the master project.

After a couple of weeks we went in a tour in the city of Gent on foot, to examine the historical locations in the city, Chokri set me up with Franky Croes, a historian who is based in Gent, the tour was in the center area of which Mr. Croes explained every monument we passed, and told us stories about some of the houses along the road, the main three locations I found interesting and would add to my research were:

- Gravensteen: The history of this castle goes back to the middle ages, it was a symbol of the region for so long, I made a visit to the castle last year and I found out that one of the armies for the second Crusader campaign actually launched from that castle under the flag of Count Philip I, the Count of Flanders (12). There I found my first connection between Gent, the city I'm doing my studies in and my homeland.
- Mammelokker: The old city prison of Gent has a plaque depicts an urban legend about a man and his daughter breastfeeding him. The man was starved to death for all his misdeeds. Fortunately for him, his daughter was allowed to visit him. Week after week passed and the man stayed alive! A miracle? Or was something or someone else involved? The monarch couldn't believe it and ordered the jailer to watch them through the peephole. Then he saw the girl hand her father a breast and let him drink. The monarch, moved by this incident, immediately released the man. Master builder David 't Kindt made this work of art as a permanent memento of this event (13). I considered this place as a reflection of the Palestinian prisoners in Israeli prisons and a graffiti project I executed in 2012 when there was more than two thousand Palestinians on hunger-strike for about a month.
- Monument of Jacob van Artevelde: He was a wealthy Ghent merchant who had sensed his chance to enter the political scene. He led a popular uprising against unemployment, made an alliance with Ypres and Bruges and succeeded in promoting a policy of neutrality, and managed to secure the neutrality of Ghent and Flanders during the 100-year war between France

and England (14). This monument was considered in reflection of the class conflict across the world.

- Dulle Griet: The Groot Kanon, also known or referred to as Grote or Dulle Griet and Red Devil, is a fully forged cannon consisting of a barrel and a chamber of forged tires. In 1783, the Groot Kanon was placed on three bluestone pedestals, decorated with festoons, on the small square where it still rests today (15). This monument resembled the conflicted relationship between war and peace, and for that I was aiming to perform on the cannon stories of war and wishes of peace for all humanity.

Performance locations:

1- Sint-Baafsabdij - (October 2020):



"St Bavo's Abbey", now "Museum of Stone Objects". To the west of the former Gallo-Roman vicus "Ganda" or the Roman Castellum, namely at the confluence of Leie and Scheldt, Saint Amandus is said to have founded a Saint Peter's church and a religious community between 630 and 639, to be identified with the Ganda Monastery, named from 864 Saint Bavo Abbey after Saint Bavo, died in the abbey in 653. The dependent Saint Bavo village or Sint-Bavostede developed around the abbey. A similar development occurred at St. Peter's Abbey, the second Ghent abbey founded by order of Saint Amandus.

It was destroyed by fire and looting during the Norman raids in 851 and 879-883. Left in ruins by the monks until the first half of the 10th century. Reconstruction from 940 on under the impetus of Count Arnulf the Great who charged Gerardus van Brogne with the reform into a Benedictine abbey. Largest construction campaign in the second half of the 12th century. Re-flowering under Abbot Raphaël de Mercatel through embellishment and adaptation works circa 1495, including the cloister. Under Pope Paul III, the monks were secularised in 1536 and transferred to a new chapter at St. John's Church, from then on called St. Bavo's Cathedral (16).

Text used in Abbey:

As a respect to the place and its significance, I started by giving the statue of Jesus wings replacing the arms that were missing with a quote from the bible:

على الارض السلام وفي الناس المسرة

"On earth peace, good will toward men"

(Luke 2:14) (18)

A part of arabic palestinian poetry by Mahmoud Darwish,

كل قلوب الناس... جنسيتي

فالتسقطوا عني جواز السفر

"All the hearts of the people are my identity

So take away my passport!"

(Mahmoud Darwish: Passport) (19)

I chose this phrase for the link between my personal struggle to defend and protect my identity as a Palestinian, and Jesus as a rebel against oppression in

the Roman era in Palestine, and the way he managed to take this struggle to the whole world in a form of a religion.

I also made abstract formations of Arabic Calligraphiti for the beauty of the characters I use while reacting with the statue.

2- STA.M: The city's Museum (April 2021):



The City Museum of Gent shows the story of Gent from the time it was established using permanent objects and shows with multimedia and artefacts. The performance was part of "Nocturne met 'SLAM Aleikum' VOLZET" (17) and took place in the church, I chose the church in the museum mainly for the effect of the Arabic Calligraphiti style of mine on the altar and the painting decorating it, the colours of that painting was revealed by the text I was writing with my style.

19Text I used in STA.M:

As a respect to the place I started with the same verse from the bible:

على الارض السلام وفي الناس المسرة

“On earth peace, good will toward men”

(Luke 2:14) (18)

I also wrote a part of old Arabic poetry:

دع دعئك لومي فإن اللوم إغراء

“Do not blame me, for blaming is temptation”

(Abu Nuwas, Classical Arabic poet 756-814 AD) (20)

In reflection of the role of religion fighting temptations, and how humans tend to defy rules if these rules were forced onto them.

Another poetry I wrote was:

دع الأيام تفعل ما تشاء

“Let days go forth”

(The intro of a poem by Imam Al-Shafi'i) (21)

I chose this text as a sign of us humans have no control over our future, and a sign of the unity of religions in general.

3- Gravensteen:



Photoshopped image of how would the performance should be, the text used in this image is from the performance of STA.M

دع دعتك لومي فإن اللوم إغراء

“Do not blame me, for blaming is temptation”
(Abu Nuwas, Classical Arabic poet 756-814 AD)

Built in 1180 by Philip of Alsace, Count of Flanders, on the site of a smaller castle from the 9th-10th centuries, it was modelled after the fortified castles erected by the Crusaders in Syria. It was the residence of the counts of Flanders until the 14th century, when they settled in the more comfortable Hof ter Walle or Prinsenhof. The stone lost its military function, it was occupied by public services (College of the Castle of Ghent, the count's minting works, Council of Flanders) and partly furnished as a prison with torture chambers. At the end of the 18th century it came into private ownership, resulting in complete disrepair: workhouses and a cotton mill were housed in it, private houses were built against the south and east sides and within the enclosure. In 1872 the gatehouse, and in 1887 the remainder was purchased by the State and City. From 1894 to 1913, after the demolition of the new buildings, thorough restoration and partial reconstruction of the heavily damaged castle on the basis of existing archaeological data, by the Ghent architect J. De Waele and afterwards by S. Mortier.

The case of Gravensteen:

Taking this huge history in consideration and the connection between Gent the city I live in and Jerusalem the capital of my homeland Palestine, and the historical facts of the crusader campaigns from Europe that passed through Gent, I planned to perform a Digital Calligraffiti session over the gate of this castle, for that I started to send emails to a cultural organisation called VOEM, operates in Antwerp, Brussels and Gent to assist me with the official dialogue with the responsible authorities: Stad Gent and Historische Huizen Gent. The

main sentence I was planning to perform was "بوصلة لا تشير الى القدس مشبوهة" *A compass that doesn't point to Jerusalem is suspicious* (22) - since the history of this castle is directly linked to Jerusalem so this building was performing as a reminder of Jerusalem at the time - the castle was a compass to Jerusalem.

I was shocked by the reply of the authorities, they simply refused that I perform any Digital Calligraffiti in public space! And as they claim it was because of Political sensitivity, and they will not discuss the matter with the public domain, as the city of Gent claims, a Digital performance on the gates of the castle was not possible, in fact they made it clear that it's not possible to do a performance on any of the landmarks that I planned to do in order to complete the research, the Light director of the city and the director of historical houses suggested some other locations with no historical or political value which will contradict with the main question that I'm researching..

I developed my own theory regarding that matter since the road came to a dead end: **Gent does not want to open the Crusaders history file!**

While the crusader campaign was initiated by the Pope to free the holy land from the Moslems, the crusaders were in fact invaders, *"they were heard to proclaim that they had come to exterminate the Muslims, although they were also seen to plunder many a Greek church on their way ... They passed through several villages, all of them Christian, and commandeered the harvests, which had just been gathered, mercilessly massacring those peasants who tried to resist. Young children were even said to have been burned alive."* (23)

Outcome:

The performance of Digital Calligraffiti on western monument its was highly appreciated by the public here in Belgium, it is a gateway for the eastern culture to present itself in a new form yet preserving the essence of the spiritually nature of the text presented in a modern way.

This fusion of past and future, the flow and the rigid created some kind of a visual stimulation that caught the eyes of the public, thew performance added a layer that highlighted a "standard western monument " and lift it to another level in a way made the public re-appreciate a monument that they were used to see for a very long time in the same form, this layer of light that the Digital Calligraffiti that was added on a facade enriched the ambiance with the organic style of mine.

Comparing to the Latin letters that are used in Europe, the Arabic way of writing and the letters is fundamentally different, it's not just written right to left but also the structure and the anatomy of the letters is totally different too, as I see it there is a harmony and a dance even in the everyday writing, what I mean by that is the Latin writing is basically written letter by letter and it has two shapes, capital and small, example the letter "B" "b", but in Arabic this is not how it goes, the letter ب (it's the second letter in Arabi alphabet and has the same sound of "B") four cases depending on the position of it in the word and the letter before it from the right, "ب ب ب ب".

Taking these information in count, the appearance of this language on western monuments sought the eyes of the audience and it raised curios questions, about the Arabic language, the heritage of the Levant, Arabic literature, also

questions about my style which opens a discussion of this intercultural performance, and discussions about the place where the performance is taking place at the time. Also the performance of the Digital Calligraffiti in a “nonEuropean” language can be seen as how the immigrants and refugees coming from all over the planet are trying to find a spot in the community, is it integration or is it a replacement of a foreign culture with the western one to “fit” the local scene? Are immigrants seen as a valuable component of the community? Are second (and later) generation of immigrants and refugees considered as an original component to the European culture? These are some questions that was raised after observing the community in Gent as a sample. I believe this project can continue on exploring more and more of the western monuments, it’s a way of celebrating these historical checkpoints with a fresh style coming from the east.

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2- Fig. 1

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Quran

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6- Fig. 5

Arabic calligraphy, (2021) *Thuluth*

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7- Fig. 6

Arabic calligraphy, (2021) *Dewani*

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